Land of the Free

WRITTEN BY

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“Complacency is the key to mediocracy.”

“I can’t breathe. Mama, help me.” The Black man, pinned down by the knee of a white officer, repeated these words. My cozy home suddenly felt freezing. A chill went through my bones when the man stopped screaming. I clenched my fists. My eyes watered. I turned off the TV and glanced at my father. Pops always hid his emotions to be strong for me. I could count on one hand how many times he’s cried in front of me. This time was different. He fought a losing battle from within. Two tears broke free. He quickly wiped them away.

“You can be angry, hurt, scared even,” Pops said, turning to face me. “But you can’t be complacent. Nothing changes from complacency.”

My mom came over and wrapped her arms around me. “Anger is useless, if you do nothing to help fix it,” she said, hugging me even tighter.

I tried to digest their words. I knew what needed to be done, but how was *I* going to fix it? My mind clouded over, holding the thunder inside. I just sat there wrapped in the protection of my parents. Then I remembered the story my pops had told me when I was 11 years old about his childhood friend, Jamarion, being killed by police officers. Pops preserved his memory by naming me Jamari Conner. I wonder if one of Pops’s tears was for Jamarion.

Chapter 1

When my pops married my mom, they wanted to raise a family in a small town, so they moved from Newburgh, New York to Laketown, Pennsylvania. The town got its name because of our beautiful lake. During the summer, visitors who stay in the grand summer houses surrounding the lake go boating and fishing. But in the winter, the frozen lake sits quietly with all the empty summer houses.

Laketown is a great place to live, but there are times when living here doesn't feel like the best option. Partly because my dad is Black and my mom is white, like most of the people who live here. Many of the residents have never experienced any other culture outside of their own. I became their "cultural experience" as soon as I started preschool. The kids used to ask me how my Black pops and my white mom could have me. Other times, the teachers and other kids would touch my hair without my permission, because it was so *different*. Ever since then, I felt different.

But the thing that bothers me the most about living here is the open display of Confederate flags. The people who live in the forested communities flaunt their flags on their houses, on their cars, and on their lawns. Even the kids in school represent "their flag history" proudly on their shirts. My older brother, Joey, told me stories about his run-ins with these "historians," and how he got into a couple of fights because of it. He taught me to pick my battles.

Focusing on basketball was the one thing that helped me close off all the negativity around me. My goal was to compete in the Amateur Athletic Union Philadelphia tournament. It's

a traveling basketball league, the biggest of the biggest. It's where players from all over the country play against one another. To get anywhere in basketball, I had to put the extra practice time in. I played on my school's basketball team, but even that came with a price. Some of the white teammates displayed the Confederate flag during practice. That always stirred me up. I would dribble the ball hard against the court to squash every Confederate image in my mind. I'd grip the ball, determined to make the shot. The sound of the ball passing through the net swished away every thought of inferiority. I was good and nobody's flag could take that away from me.

After a week hard-fought against tests, racism, and other stupid teenage drama, I liked to spend my weekends playing ball and hanging with my friends. On Saturday morning, after a few phone calls, the crew was ready to go hoopin' at the park. My friend Noah swung by to pick me up.

When we got there, the court was filled with kids ready to play. Just as we were about to pick our teams, Tommy, one of my white teammates from school, pulled up with his crew in his lifted pickup truck. The Confederate and American flags both flew from his truck bed. Obviously, me and Tommy didn't talk much, so seeing him at the park took me completely by surprise.

"What's up, my guys!" Tommy screamed as he led his entourage toward the court. "Whoooooooa! Were y'all really going to start without the best hooper in town? Besides Ja, of course, but he has a special advantage." He smirked at me, while the rest of his crew laughed. Being Black, in their narrow minds, automatically made me good at playing basketball. It took all I had not to go over to him and start a problem.

"Li'l Tommy's crew versus mine. How does that sound?" I asked.

"This is going to be an easy win," my best friend, Collin, whispered.

"Let's do this," I told Tommy as I threw the ball to him. My team scored easily, and Tommy's team had trouble getting past us. He turned red from either embarrassment or exhaustion. Me and my team took over the court, shaking and baking. It didn't matter how Tommy felt about me. I beat his racism on the court.

"That's all you boys got?" I said, smirking at Tommy as I dribbled the ball toward him.

My quick crossover shifted Tommy right out of my way. I took a jump shot and the ball *swished* through the net. My team was one point away from winning the game. I turned to Tommy. "It's okay. You're trying your best and that's all that matters."

I guess my sarcasm wasn't amusing to Tommy. The next time I dribbled the ball past him, he pushed me to the ground. I sprung up and got into his face.

"What was that?" I yelled.

"You should know, Ja." Tommy said, smiling. "Don't *your people* call it 'streetball?'"

I lost it. I pushed him back. Collin and Noah ran over and got between us.

Tommy backed away. "I'll see you around, Ja," Tommy said, slinking toward his truck. His crew followed. They yelled something I couldn't understand out the window. Tommy kept blowing his horn as he sped off. I stood there watching them until his flags were out of sight.

"Don't even sweat it, Ja. All he wants to do is get in your head," Collin said.

My body tensed. Anger stole all my words. I nodded.

We went on playing our game. I dribbled the ball hard against the court and took a shot.

Swish!

Chapter 2

On Sunday, my adrenaline was up. My big brother, Joey, had just come home from college to watch me compete in the AAU Philly tournament. School would be out in a few days, which left me with a little over a month to practice.

"Yo, Joey," I said, walking into my old bedroom.

"What's up li'l man?" Joey asked, lying on what used to be my twin bed.

When Joey moved out to go to college, I took his bigger and better room.

"First, I'm not a li'l man anymore, I can take you now," I said. I knew I couldn't actually take him, but I needed to challenge his dominance.

"Oh yeah? You think you're a big guy now because you grew a little bit since my visit?" he said, getting up from his bed.

"Let's do it!" I insisted.

We started lightly scrapping but he had me. I wasn't giving up; I couldn't lose so easily. After a couple seconds, he brought me to the floor with a loud THUD!

"Boys! What's going on up there?" Mom yelled from downstairs.

"Nothing, Mom," we said in unison.

"Joey, I was wondering if you could drive me to practice tonight?" I asked, getting up from the floor.

"Of course. It's in Scranton, right? Like an hour away?" Joey asked.

"Yup."

“What time do you have to be there?” he asked.

“Five thirty,” I said.

“And it’s four o’clock right now, Bro? Why don’t you tell me any later?” he said, rolling his eyes.

“Shut up,” I replied.

“Well let's go, we got to book it.”

We ran downstairs to see if we could use Pops’s car. To my surprise, Pops handed over the keys to his new Durango, but not without saying, “Don’t forget whose car this is. Drive it like you got some sense.”

“Of course,” Joey said.

As we closed the front door behind us, Joey winked at me, “Let’s do this.”

Music flooded the car as soon as Joey turned the ignition. Me and Joey fell into a groove, singing the lyrics of familiar songs, from Drake, Jay-Z, to J. Cole. It felt like old times.

Joey dropped me off at practice and I told him to pick me up at 7:30. He said he’d kill some time by riding around the small city to see the sights.

Practice was hard, exhausting and long, as it should be. Coach Ron always said, “The practice should be much harder than the game, to make the game easier.” He was one of the few Black coaches in our area, and possibly the only one who had his own team. He played professionally and somehow found himself here.

Some of the guys stayed around for a little to play ball. After about 10 minutes, Joey appeared in the doorway of the gym. Collin screamed, “Joey! What’s up man? I didn’t know you were in town.”

“What’s up, Collin,” Joey said, walking toward us. He turned to me, looking disappointed. “So, you didn’t tell them I was home, Ja? I guess I have to make my presence known. Let’s play some ball.”

It was me and Collin versus Joey and Noah. I guarded Joey, of course. Basketball was one thing I wasn’t going to let Joey beat me in. Joey got the ball and did a double crossover, switching the ball from one hand to the other, so fast it caught me off-guard. He got to the basket and made a layup.

“OOOOOOOO,” some of kids on the sidelines yelled.

“How you like that, li’l man?” Joey asked.

“That was cute, but it’s not happening again,” I replied.

Joey got the ball back and this time he tried to dribble it through his legs. I wasn’t about to let him get me again. I jumped the move and took the ball from him. I stepped back and took a shot. *Swish!*

“The best sound in the world,” I said.

“Lucky shot,” Joey said.

We played until 9 o’clock. The final score was 11 to 9 in my favor. But I had to admit Joey still had a little something left in him. “One more game,” I insisted.

"You got school tomorrow," Joey said. "And the Philly tournament is a month away. I don't want you to overwork yourself, li'l man."

"Yeah, let's see who's gonna be the li'l man once I make it to the pros."

I waved bye to the guys and headed out. Joey put his arm around my shoulder. I could tell he was proud of me. His li'l brother was going places.

Chapter 3

BEEEEP! My alarm went off at 6:20 the next morning. I got up and rushed to get ready for school.

At school, only one or two people looked like me. There were a few Confederate flag apparel wearers and a few wanna-be kids who *tried* to look "like me." It's easy to tell inauthenticity pretty quick. But most of the kids were average white kids.

I had started preschool with a lot of them. That was when I didn't have a voice and an answer for my identity. But as I got a little older, I always wondered why we had days off for hunting season but not Martin Luther King, Jr. Day. Or why the students in my class looked at me when the teacher talked about any form of racism. While it felt uncomfortable to learn about racism in front of a class filled with white students, it felt even worse not including Black history in the lessons about American history.

When I was in 5th grade, I told my pops, "Black history is American history, so why don't we learn about it?"

"The past can be scary for some people," he explained. "It's not fair, but *you* have a voice. Use it."

I thought about what Pops told me. I wrote a letter to my principal about including Black history in American history lessons. She was thrilled and took me into her office to congratulate me on my efforts. She encouraged me to keep advocating. I walked out of her office feeling happy. I believed a change was coming. I couldn't have been more wrong. Nothing happened

after our meeting. I felt like I had lost. I don't like losing. Year after year I kept writing letters and kept meeting with school officials, yet nothing changed. I discovered that the people I met with would rather have quiet than equality.

But I'm not one to keep quiet, especially since I usually attracted a lot of attention in the halls. And rightfully so, as the most valuable player on the school's basketball team. "Hey, Ja," people from every direction called out this morning.

I gave my nonchalant head nod like I was somebody famous. The day was a typical boring school day. During the offseason of basketball, some of the kids from the team lifted weights, so I stayed after school as usual. By the time I finished, I got a text from Joey, saying he was picking me up. He pulled up in Pops's ride.

"Whooooa, Pops is being nice with the Durango, huh?" I said.

"He knows how responsible I am," Joey said.

"More like he knows how broke you are. Poor college student who can't even afford your own car," I said, laughing.

"Shut up and get in," Joey said. "Let's start this convo over. How was school? Are you hungry?

"Now that's responsibility. Of course, I'm hungry. And school was good," I said.

"I'll stop by the new gas station to grab a snack, but Mom is making your favorite dinner tonight. Empanadas," Joey said. "So we can't ruin your appetite."

Joey turned into the gas station's parking lot. The store had been newly renovated and renamed Stewie's Quikmart. It was much bigger than the other gas stations in the area. It had a

grand feel, like walking into a Target rather than a corner store. People were constantly in and out, so they put a police officer by the front entrance. The officer never paid much attention to me when I walked in with Collin or Noah, but as soon as Joey and I walked in, he followed us into every section of the store.

"Why doesn't he ever pay attention to the kids who are actually stealing?" I asked Joey.

"Because they look like him," Joey said. "White."

"Oh, that's right," I said. "Even when they do steal, they're just 'young and dumb.' But us, we're automatically 'dangerous thugs.'"

Me and Joey just snickered and gave sideways glances at the officer, who pretended to be very interested in the potato chips only a few feet away from us.

We made our way up to the counter, and I slowly reached into my pocket to pull out my wallet. Joey taught me to never make a sudden move in front of an officer. He said sudden movements by Black people made officers feel threatened. But sometimes, they claimed to feel threatened even when Blacks didn't move at all, like the killing of George Floyd that I had just witnessed on TV a few weeks ago. And we'd heard other stories of Freddie Gray, Michael Brown, Jr., Laquan McDonald, Eric Garner . . . the list goes on and on. Paying for a Gatorade and Hot Cheetos in the store could quickly turn deadly if you were a Black person.

When we walked out the door, the officer finally returned to his original spot. Joey and I glanced behind us to see if he was watching us out of the window. He was! Joey made an exaggerated stretch of his arm as he clicked the key fob to unlock the doors of Pops's Durango.

"What's all that for?" I asked.

"To show Baldy that we actually have keys for the car," Joey said, laughing.

As we reached the car, Joey put his hand over the top of his head to appear bald. He bent his knees to make himself look shorter, and he followed me around the car like the officer had done inside the store.

I spit out Gatorade while laughing. "Didn't he have a huge forehead, though?" I said.

I looked toward the store, but all I saw was the officer's back. He had missed Joey's impersonation of him. Joey finally stopped following me around the car and let me get inside. He rolled down the windows and blasted the music. The officer looked startled as he glared at us through the store window.

Joey stared back at him with a smirk.

"Joey!" I said, lowering the music.

"Yo! Don't touch my music." Joey said, turning toward me. "You just messed up my moment of victory."

"Look at the back corner of the lot," I said, pointing to a cop car.

Joey's face got sober, and he turned the music down so low we could barely hear it. He backed out of the parking space, put the car into drive, and slowly moved towards the main street. Joey kept checking his mirrors while he drove. He started making me nervous. I turned around to look out the back window. The cop car was following us. Joey stopped at a stop sign, put on his right turn signal, and looked both ways. As he made the right turn onto a street a few blocks away from our house, we heard a police siren.

Chapter 4

"Is he coming after us?" I asked Joey.

"There's only one way to find out," Joey said, pulling the car over into a vacant lot.

He turned off the music.

As expected, the cop car pulled in right behind us.

"What did we even do?" I said, sucking my teeth.

"It doesn't matter if we did anything or not, so just shut up and listen!" Joey said.

When Joey and I were younger, our pops taught us what to do if a police officer stopped us while driving. "Keep your hands on the steering wheel or dashboard at all times," he said. "Only move when he tells you to."

We sat as calmly as possible. Joey looked in the rearview mirror, while I looked into the passenger mirror. Two white male officers stepped out of the car. One was tall and skinny with blond hair, wearing sunglasses. The other officer was much older and bald, with a thick mustache.

Mustache walked over and stood next to my window. Sunglasses went to Joey's window. "License and registration," he commanded Joey.

Joey held the steering wheel. "I have to reach in my back pocket to get my license, officer," Joey said, sounding like a robot.

Sunglasses put his hand over his gun and said, "Just move slow."

Joey slowly got his wallet and then said, “Now I have to reach inside my glove box to get the registration card, officer.”

“Go ahead,” Sunglasses said.

Joey handed Sunglasses his license and the registration card.

Sunglasses examined Joey’s information. “Nice ride. Do you own it?” he asked.

“It’s my pop’s car,” Joey said, with a shaky voice. Joey’s face turned ashen. I could tell he was scared. I had never seen Joey scared before, and that made me scared. Sunglasses walked back to his car with Pops’s information and Mustache started to follow.

“I need to get Pops on the phone,” Joey said.

“Joey, we’re not supposed to move unless we’re told to!” I said.

Of course, he didn’t listen to me. He reached into his pocket for his phone. I looked back to make sure the cops weren’t coming back, but I locked eyes with Mustache staring at us through the back window.

“Put the phone down!” I whispered, a bit too loudly.

“They can’t see me,” Joey responded, trying to dial pop’s number.

“Hey, don’t move!” Mustache yelled.

Sunglass approached the car with his gun drawn. “Put your hands up,” he said.

Joey raised his hands. His phone hit the **c**enter console with a THUD.

“Step out of the car!” Sunglasses screamed at Joey.

"Both of you!" Mustache shouted, standing at my window. "Now!"

Joey got out slowly, but I stayed in the car.

"Why did you even pull us over?" I asked Mustache.

"Get out!" he demanded.

The image of George Floyd being killed by a cop flashed before me. I thought about how my pops lost his best friend at the hands of cops, and countless other stories of Black people harassed by the police. I grew angry. I heard my mom's voice in my head saying, "Anger is useless, if you do nothing to help fix it." This time I knew what I had to do. I didn't move.

Mustache opened my door and yanked me out of the car. It hurt a whole lot, but not as much as seeing Sunglasses slam my brother across the hood of the car.

"Stop! Don't hurt him!" Joey yelled at Mustache.

"Shut up!" both officers shouted. In a split second, Mustache threw me to the ground, knocking the wind out of me. Before I could get myself together, he started kicking me. I took four kicks to the ribs before I heard a crack. Mustache must have heard it, too. He took out his baton and started beating me on my head. I tried shielding myself with my arms. "Stop resisting!" he shouted.

Resisting? How is a kid getting his brain beat out be resisting?

"Stop! You're going to kill him!" Joey screamed at Mustache.

Sunglasses walked over to me, pulling Joey along by his handcuffed wrists.

"Do something," Joey yelled at Sunglasses. "Stop him!"

I turned to look at Sunglasses. He looked stunned. But instead of doing anything to help me, he turned his face away and walked Joey toward his police car. Joey's yells became faint and turned into white noise, almost like a constant ringing. Everything was blurry. I heard a distant, "Love you, Bro."

I tried to respond, but all I could get out was "I love—" before everything went black.

Chapter 5

I heard voices and sirens, but I couldn't move. I felt my body being pulled into a dark empty space. The noises faded away. Faint glimmers of white light flashed around me. *So this is what heaven looks like?* I thought to myself. *Disappointing*.

I started walking. My sneakers creaked on an invisible path. At the end of the path, a bright light shined down on a giant Being sitting on a crystal throne. He looked and dressed like me. Only he was a hundred times bigger than I am.

"Whooaaa! Is this a dream?" I asked.

"No," he said.

"So, am I dead?" I asked.

"Not yet. You have to make a decision," he said. "And you don't have much time."

"A decision about what?" I asked.

"About whether you are going to fight to make things better or give up."

"I don't know what to do anymore," I said. "I've been fighting to make things better since fifth grade and this is where I ended up. Half-dead."

"So does that mean you're giving up?" the Being asked.

"Should I? I mean you're a bigger version of myself, so tell me what I should do."

"I am only your mind. *You* have to decide," the Being said before fading away.

"Wait," I yelled. But he was gone.

A beautiful wooden door appeared where the Being once sat. A white spotlight shined on the center of the door, revealing an etched image of strong fists bound with shackles. I thought about seeing Joey in handcuffs. Then the spotlight shifted to a word underneath the image: BONDAGE.

I touched the doorknob, but it was freezing. I pulled my hand back. I pushed on the door and fell through, dropping into an empty space. My screams echoed above me. After what felt like a year, I saw a faint glimmer of light. As the ground became closer, I braced myself for the impact.

I landed softly in a field. I stood up to look around. To my left, Black enslaved people were working in a cotton field near a few rundown sheds. To my right was a grand plantation house.

A white man on horseback wore a tall top hat over his long brown hair. He trotted to the field and dismounted his horse. He snatched a young Black boy by his collar and dragged him across the field. I yelled for him to leave the boy alone, but no one seemed to hear me.

“Mama! Papa!” the boy yelled.

A Black woman ran to the edge of the field. “What did he do, sir?”

“He’s being sold,” said the overseer.

“My baby!” the woman screamed, reaching for her child.

“Mama, I don’t wanna go, please help me,” the boy cried.

A dark-skinned Black man sprinted across the field towards them. The overseer pulled out his pistol and fired a shot into the air. The Black man stopped. My heart raced with fear and anger.

"I'd hate to make an example out of him," said the overseer. "Now get back to work."

The overseer shackled the boy's wrists before mounting his horse. Walking alongside the horse, the boy's small body faded in the distance.

His mother fell to her knees and cried. His father wrapped his arms around her, with tears rolling down his broad cheek. I remembered Pop's tears and how he was always there to protect me. It was all so unfair. That boy might never see his father again. The scene started to fade around me. *Would I ever see mine?*

Chapter 6

Darkness surrounded me again. The Being reappeared, sitting on his crystal throne.

“Hey, there you are,” I said. “Why’d you disappear like that?”

“You needed time to think,” the Being said. “Have you made your decision yet?”

“How is showing me a kid being snatched away from his family helping me make my decision?” I asked. “I can’t change history.”

“No, but history can change you,” the Being said, before fading away.

“Huh? No, come back here,” I yelled. But he was gone again.

Another beautiful wooden door appeared where the Being once sat. A white spotlight shined on an etched image of a raised fist. Underneath the image were the words: BLACK POWER.

I pushed the door open and stepped through, preparing myself for the fall. I soft-landed inside a community center. No one noticed me. I figured I was still invisible. The center was set up like a cafeteria. Over one of the tables hung a large banner that read: **Black Panther Party: All Power to the People.**

My pops had told me about the Black Panthers and how they organized to protect Black people and their communities.

Black Panther members were serving breakfast to children in the neighborhood before they headed to school. As the children ate, one of the members of the Black Panther Party yelled out, "Who invented the first clock in America?"

"A Black man," the children yelled.

"That's right, his name was Benjamin Banneker. And you can be inventors, too."

The children raised their fists into the air and shouted, "Yeah!"

"You are revolutionaries. You're strong enough to make changes."

"Tell 'em, Fred!" A woman yelled from across the room.

Wait, is this Fred Hampton? I thought*. He's giving Black history lessons over breakfast? Why didn't I learn any of this in school?*

My pops had told me that Fred Hampton fought against Black oppression in the 1960s. I walked over to get a closer look at him. I noticed a mirror on the wall behind him. I smiled at my reflection. I was wearing a black beret and leather jacket. I liked how I looked as a revolutionary. Just as I adjusted my beret, the scene faded.

Before I could protest, I found myself inside a bedroom in an apartment. I looked down and saw Fred Hampton sleeping. I tipped-toed out of the room, even though I knew he couldn't hear me. I walked through the living room, past other Black Panther members asleep on the couch and the floor. One member sat in a chair by the door. It was stuffy inside, so I headed outside to get some fresh air.

Before I went back inside, a Peoples Gas truck pulled up. Fourteen white cops, dressed in plain clothes, got out carrying pistols, a shotgun, and a machine gun. I knew what was about to

happen. The Black Panthers found ways to resist, but the system was still set up against them. I stood in front of the door, hoping I could block it. But I was helpless. The cops rushed past me and kicked down the front door to Fred's apartment. "No-o-o-o-o!" I yelled.

A chill came over my body and my ears started ringing. I heard faint beeping sounds in the distance. They grew louder. *Beep . . . beep . . . beep . . . BEEP!*

I was jolted into a cold room. When I opened my eyes, everything was blurry. But I was able to make out my parents standing over me.

"Mom, Pops, where am I? What's that beeping?"

My mom put her hand over mine, "You're in the hospital, sweetie," she said softly. "You're hooked up to a heart monitor."

"Hospital?" I said.

Beep . . . beep . . . beep . . . everything went black.

Chapter 7

When I opened my eyes, I felt my body floating in a white mass that reminded me of clouds. I raised my body to stand, but nothing was under my feet. I tried walking anyway. With each echoed step, the white mass slowly disappeared.

A huge set of crystal doors appeared and opened. The Being was standing in the doorway. He pulled me inside and the doors shut behind us.

“So, what is *this* place?” I asked.

“This is the afterlife." he said. “A place where you won’t have to worry about pain and suffering.”

“So am I dead now?” I asked.

“Not yet, but almost,” he said. “Let me take you on a tour.”

The Being pulled me in the direction of what looked like a little town. There were gyms, restaurants, houses, and nature parks. Thousands of Black people walked around, but I noticed a few familiar faces: Trayvon Martin, Freddie Gray, Eric Garner, and Laquan McDonald.

We continued our walk and I recognized Breonna Taylor, Michael Brown, Jr., John Crawford, Sandra Bland, and Khalief Browder. Then, I noticed a kid around my age standing alone. He kept staring at me like he knew me from somewhere, but I didn’t recognize him. Before I got a chance to say anything to him, the Being pulled me in a different direction.

“Now you get to let go of all the things that bothered you in life, and finally be at peace,” the Being said.

I couldn't lie; being released from the struggles of Laketown sounded nice.

"I'll let you get settled in," the Being said, before fading away.

"Wait! But you said I wasn't dead yet," I said, but it was too late.

Once the Being was gone, the kid who had been staring ran up to me. "You look familiar," he said. "You look like my best friend Quinn Connor."

My heart dropped. "That's my dad," I said. "Who are you?"

"I'm Jamarion Lewis. Me and your dad grew up in City Terrace."

"You're Jamarion? My dad told me about you," I said. "He named me after you. I'm Jamari."

"Jamari, huh? That has a nice ring to it," Jamarion said. smiling.

"So, what is this place?" I asked.

"This is the branch of the afterlife for people who died because of racism," Jamarion said.

"Oh. My pops told me how you were killed by the police, but he never really told me the details."

"Well, now you get to hear it firsthand," Jamarion said.

Chapter 8

It was a cool summer night in Newburgh, New York. Your pops and I were around your age. School was out and my only sense of time was the switch between day and night. Back in my day, once the streetlights turned on, you had better be in the house. But this summer was different. My pops had lifted my curfew. I had more time to hang out with my boys. It was seven of us wanna-be-tough-but-harmless Black boys from the neighborhood, who all grew up together. We called ourselves Terrordome because our street was City Terrace.

We kept out of trouble by shooting a little ball and talking trash to one another. I was the instigator of the group, and I always got after your pops. “Aye, Q! You got no game,” I said. “You keep telling us about all the phone numbers you get from girls, but we’ve never seen one.” The whole group started laughing.

“Are you serious?” your pops shot back. “I can get any girl I want.” But the crew kept laughing.

“Q, you haven’t pulled one girl since ninth grade!” a guy named Dray added.

“It’s not even like that, it's just . . .”

A trio of officers approaching ended the words battle real quick. One Black officer trailed in the gap between two white cops. One of the white cops had caterpillar-looking eyebrows, and the other one wore long, shiny black shoes that looked like boats coming to shore. Their V-shaped pattern was like a crocodile’s mouth going after prey.

“What y’all up to?” Caterpillar Eyebrows asked.

His face was stern, but fear was in his eyes, even though we were just kids. Terrodome could've taken down Caterpillar Eyebrows before those wide blue eyes could blink, but his badge prevented us.

"Not much li'l man," I said, laughing. I stood behind your pops.

"Oh, you thugs think you're funny?" said Boat Feet.

"Do you pigs ever do anything besides terrorize our community?" I said.

Your pops gave me a side-eye why-can't-you-just-shut-up-for-even-a-second glance that only my mom could replicate.

I regret what I said. Not because I was wrong, but because it led to my death.

"This kid's a comedian," said the Black cop.

We all knew him. He was ol' man Thompson's son. Ol' man Thompson was the meanest dude around. He hated kids and it only got worse in his old age. Everyone in our neighborhood knew that his son was a man against his own people. Just like Judas in the Bible. We considered him a traitor. Your pops and I wondered if Black Judas was empowered by the badge, or scared, too.

At that point, all we wanted to do was make it home alive. Your pops looked like he knew the night wasn't going to end in our favor. He rocked back and forth, before trying to run. He was stopped short by a blow to the head from Black Judas's nightstick. When Q dropped to the ground, the rest of the crew ran in every direction. Caterpillar Eyebrows made sure to catch me. He and his sidekick, Boat Feet, beatdown on me. That's all I remember before everything went black.

Chapter 9

"Wait! My pops told me the rest of this story," I said. "He said while the white cops were beating you, Black Judas handcuffed him and walked him to his car down the block. When they drove back up, you were unconscious. My pops said he yelled at Black Judas, '"Why don't you help him!"

I saw tears swell in Jamarion's eyes.

"My pops said Black Judas looked shocked. I guess he had realized what he had been a part of. The two white cops stood over your body, waiting for the ambulance. But by the time it arrived, it was too late."

"What happened to your pops?" Jamarion asked.

"He was taken to jail and went to court for resisting arrest and other made-up charges. He was forced to take a plea bargain for a misdemeanor, pay a fine, and perform community service," I said. "I guess his experience is what made him warn me and my brother, Joey, about how to handle ourselves around police officers. Too bad I didn't listen."

"What are talking about?" Jamarion asked. "Were you killed by the cops too?"

"I was beaten by a cop and then I blacked out. The last thing I remember is being in the hospital," I said.

Jamarion placed his hand over my chest. "I can barely feel it, but you still have a heartbeat," he said.

"We've got one!" he yelled to everyone. All the people rushed over to us.

"Listen, Jamari," Jarmarion said in a hushed whisper. "We've been waiting for someone to come here at the right moment. We still want to fight, but we can't go back. You're not dead yet, so you can go back and fight for us."

For the first time, I saw smiles on everyone's faces. "What do I have to do?" I asked.

"Go back through the crystal doors," he said.

"But what about the Being?" I asked.

"No buts! You're almost out of time," Jamarion said. "You have to go back now!"

The crowd lifted me up and carried me toward the crystal doors. Before we could reach them, the Being rose from his throne to block us "What is this?" he said in a loud voice.

"We're here to protest," Jamarion said. "And Jamari will be our voice."

The crowd put me down and I stepped forward to confront the Being. "I made my decision," I said. "I'm going to fight."

BEEP, BEEP, BEEEEEEEEEEEEEEP!

The noise was so loud, everyone covered their ears. Then everything went silent.

"It's too late," the Being said. "Your time ran out."

"NO!" I screamed. "Why does it have to end this way for my people?"

I looked around at the disappointed faces of the people who stood behind me. They had carried me on their shoulders. I thought about how helpless the little Black boy was against the overseer, and how helpless Fred Hampton was against his murderers. Then I remembered something the Being had said. *"I am only your mind. You have to decide."*

"I'm going back," I said.

"You can't!" the Being yelled.

"*I* control my mind," I said.

Jamarion's face lit up, and he pointed toward the crystal doors. On the other side of the doors, my body lying on the hospital bed. My mom and pops were crying over me. The doors started slowly disappearing. I ran toward them.

"No, you can't leave!" the Being yelled.

He got up to run after me, but Jamarion and the rest of the group stood in front of him. The echo of my footsteps made the floor disappear beneath my feet. The doors faded away faster and faster.

"Run, Jamari," Jamarion shouted.

I looked over my shoulder and saw the Being break through the crowd. He was coming after me. Thousands of people ran behind him.

I ran faster. I knew they wanted me to make it, not just for me, or even for themselves, but for the people they had left behind. They wanted to make sure we didn't have another Trayvon Martin, or Jamarion Lewis.

I burst through the crystal doors just as they disappeared completely. Black.

Chapter 10

Once I felt the chill come over my body, I shot up in the bed and gasped for breath. The monitor beeped wildly. I was back.

My mom and pops stood over me in shock. Doctors and nurses flooded into the room. My parents smothered me in hugs. My body ached. It felt like my parents were going to squeeze my new life right out of me.

"Stand back, we have to check his vitals," a doctor said, shooing my parents away.

I looked around the doctor to see my parents. "Where's Joey?"

"In another room," my pops said. "But he's going to be ok, he just has a few scratches and bruises."

After the doctor left, my parents came back over to my bed. The TV was on, and I saw my face flash on the screen. I tried to reach for my mom, but my hand was cuffed to the bed. "Why am I cuffed?" I asked. "I didn't do anything."

*"*Why can't you uncuff him?" my pops asked someone standing behind me.

The person walked over to the side of my bed. A cop. Suddenly, I couldn't breathe. Before the cop touched me, the news reporter on television said, "The Chief of Police has released a statement saying the officers in question used justifiable force against teenager, Jamari Connor, who was resisting arrest."

"That's not the truth!" I yelled.

Everyone just stared at me.

"That's the problem with this country," I said, looking the cop dead in the eye. "Those officers beat me for nothing and now they're telling lies to justify themselves."

"I'm not uncuffing you," the cop said. He walked to the corner of the room.

My mom rested her hand on my shoulder. I saw angry tears forming in her eyes.

"Don't worry, Mom. I'm going to fix the anger," I said. "I got something to say, too."

Epilogue

I was released from the hospital after 10 days, but it took 18 months for me to fully recover after receiving physical and mental therapy. During my first week at home, I went on social media and saw bodycam footage of Joey and me being beaten helplessly. The public went into an uproar, and our names circulated throughout America. Sunglasses and Mustache were put on trial for attempted murder. But of course, they were found not guilty as they, "felt their lives were threatened by two unarmed Black males."

I made my rounds doing interviews for different news organizations, telling my story and soon the public became outraged at the jury's decision for Mustache and Sunglasses. The only sense of justice my family found was the police department covering our medical bills.

I wasn't able to play basketball my junior year, which also ended my participation in AAU tournaments. By my senior year, I was well enough to return to the basketball team. Although I never reached the same status in my basketball career, it felt great to step on the court one last time.

After graduating from high school, I knew what I wanted to do with my life: fight back. Even though my experience with police brutality didn't have the outcome I wanted, I was determined to make sure people coming after me got justice. I majored in criminal justice, and after college I got my law degree. I became a civil rights attorney and won a few landmark cases that helped pass police reform bills. I was invited to speak at the U.S. Capitol. about my story. Never once did I take my foot off the gas, and I never will.

Acknowledgments:

My first dedication of this book is to my mother and father. Without their continued love and support I would not be in the position I am today. Next, I'd like to thank my big brother and sister-in-law, who are always one call away and helped shape me into the person I am. To my grandparents, who always wanted constant updates about when they were getting a book, here it is, and to all my other family and friends who have backed me since I started writing letters to the board of education in 4th grade, thank you.

I'd like to start by saying I'm honored. I'm honored because obviously this is a rare opportunity that few people can accomplish. But I am honored because two generations ago, my existence as a biracial kid was outlawed in the Land of the Free. I am honored because where I am today is a product of my ancestors' struggle. Three summers ago, the country watched the murder of George Floyd, for 8 minutes and 46 seconds. I, a 13-year-old, watched a man beg for his life and ultimately have his life taken from him. I sat there disgusted, but not surprised. I was stripped of the "bliss of ignorance" my whole life. Not because I wanted to, but because I had to . . . to survive. For some people, the summer of 2020 was a time of awakening, but for me and many others like me, it was nothing new. In 2018, my unarmed cousin, Marcus Peters, was shot and killed by officers in the state of Virginia. His murder was justified by the Land of the Free, so, how can I feel safe?

No student should feel afraid to play in the park, yet Tamir Rice is dead. No kid should be afraid of visiting their family, yet Trayvon Martin is dead. No one should be afraid of sitting in their apartment, yet Breonna Taylor is dead. No generation of my ancestors born in America existed without having fear instilled in them. My book was created not only from my image of

America, but also from my image of my hometown. I'm taught to act a certain way and speak a certain way just to get by. These are reasons why I wrote this book, but why should I have to write it? A 13-year-old should not have to write a book about always feeling threatened for his life.

Some may see my title, *The Land of the Free*, as mockery against this nation. But when you look deeper into this story, there is a message of hope. Most parents can agree that no child is perfect, and it is the parents' duty to help their child with their flaws. The same idea applies to our country. It is the citizens' job to help their nation recognize and fix its problems. As an American, the most patriotic thing to do is not to blindly state that our country is perfect, and overlook our issues, but to stand up to systemic racism and make a change for the better, because that is what loving parents do.

I'm not here to brag about personal accolades and accomplishments, but instead I'm here to say, while we've come far as a nation, it is not the end, and systemic change will help us scale the mountain, and you can be a part of making that change.